

TEEN & TWEEN COMMUNICATION WORKBOOK

50 Conversation Starters, Scripts for Hard Topics & Trust-Building Tools

By Daniel Tesfamariam

THE TEEN BRAIN: WHY COMMUNICATION BREAKS DOWN

Teens are not trying to be difficult. Their prefrontal cortex is literally rewiring.

They need: autonomy, respect, privacy, AND your guidance.

Rule #1: LISTEN more than you lecture. Ask more than you tell.

Rule #2: Side-by-side (car, cooking) works better than face-to-face.

Rule #3: Timing matters. Not when they're hungry, tired, or in front of friends.

50 NON-INVASIVE CONVERSATION STARTERS

(Use during car rides, walks, or cooking - NOT face-to-face interrogation)

1. What was the best part of your day?
2. What stressed you out this week?
3. If you could change one thing about school?
4. What are your friends into that you don't understand?
5. Who do you sit with at lunch?
6. Is there anyone at school you're worried about?
7. What do you wish I understood about being a teen?
8. If you could have any superpower, what and why?
9. What surprised you recently?
10. Anything you've been wanting to tell me?
11. What do you want life to look like in 5 years?
12. What's hardest about being your age?
13. Who do you admire and why?
14. What would you do with \$1000?
15. Any topic you wish we discussed more openly?
16. Which rule of ours do you think is unfair?
17. Kindest thing someone did for you recently?
18. What makes a good friend?
19. Anything happening online that worries you?
20. Do you need more space or more togetherness from me?
21. How would you describe our relationship to friends?
22. What's your biggest fear right now?
23. Is there peer pressure to do things you're uncomfortable with?
24. What would make home feel safer?
25. What are you most proud of about yourself?

SCRIPTS FOR HARD CONVERSATIONS

SOCIAL MEDIA & ONLINE SAFETY

"I'm not trying to spy. I want to understand your world. Can you show me what you like about [platform]? What worries me is..."

DRUGS & ALCOHOL

"I know you'll be around this stuff. I'd rather talk honestly than pretend it doesn't exist. What have you seen?"

SEX & RELATIONSHIPS

"This might feel awkward for both of us. I want you to have accurate info and know you can always come to me."

MENTAL HEALTH

"I've noticed you seem [tired/withdrawn/stressed]. I'm not judging. How are you really doing?"

BULLYING

"Has anyone made you feel small or scared? You won't get in trouble. I'm on your team."

THEIR MISTAKES

"Everyone messes up. I'm more interested in what you learned than in punishing you. Tell me what happened."

PHONE & SOCIAL MEDIA CONTRACT

This phone belongs to [parent] and is loaned to [teen] under these terms:

- ☐ Phone charges in kitchen at night (not bedroom)
- ☐ Parent may check phone with notice (not secretly)
- ☐ No sharing personal info/location with strangers
- ☐ No downloading apps without discussion
- ☐ Respond to parent messages within 30 minutes
- ☐ No phone during family meals or homework
- ☐ Report any bullying, threats, or uncomfortable contact
- ☐ Phone privilege reviewed monthly
- ☐ Consequences for breaking contract: _____

Signed: Teen _____ Parent _____ Date ____/____/____

TRUST-BUILDING CHALLENGES

1. Have a no-phone dinner and really talk
2. Let them teach YOU something they're good at
3. Share an embarrassing story from YOUR teen years
4. Give them a decision to make (and respect it)
5. Write each other a letter about what you appreciate
6. Do their hobby together (even if you're terrible)
7. Stay up 30 min later for a real conversation
8. Apologize for something specific you got wrong

WARNING SIGNS: WHEN TO GET PROFESSIONAL HELP

Trust your gut. If something feels wrong, ACT.

MENTAL HEALTH RED FLAGS:

- Withdrawal from friends/family lasting 2+ weeks
- Major sleep changes (too much or too little)
- Giving away possessions
- Talking about being a burden or not wanting to be here
- Self-harm signs (cuts, burns, scratches)

SUBSTANCE USE:

- Sudden friend group change
- Secretive behavior / missing money
- Red eyes, slurred speech, new smells

CRISIS: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (call or text 988)

By Daniel Tesfamariam | The teen who pushes you away needs you most.